

Creature Art Spec

The Character Bible says who the cast is. This says whether the cast *works* — every silhouette tested at the size players actually see it, with the collisions named and a fix for each. Hand this to the illustrator with the Bible.

[← Character Bible](#)[All screens](#)

Calls I made for you

REVERSE ANY OF THESE AND I'LL REDRAW

BIOLOGICAL FAMILY

Shell and carapace

Your existing founders already lean this way — Vetch is a shell-back, Ember has a vent crest. Plated bodies also make Carapace and Pierce *literal*: plate versus the thing that punches through plate. The matrix reads as biology instead of arbitrary rock-paper-scissors.

RAIDERS VS FOUNDERS

Angular, not corrupted

Canon already answered this: your raider art is dark and hard-edged where founders are pastel and convex. I kept it and made it a rule — **founders are convex curves, raiders are straight lines and corners**. That single axis is what lets a player read friend-or-foe before reading anything else.

RENDER TARGET

Inked outline, flat fill

A dark contour (#3f3a52, the UI ink) with flat pastel inside. Gradients turn to mud at 40px and stipple disappears entirely; an ink line holds the shape at every size and already matches the interface.

PROOF STRICTNESS

Black fill, no colour

Every shape below is tested as a solid black mass. If two creatures are only tellable apart once colour arrives, the shape has failed — colour is the fourth channel a player uses, never the first.

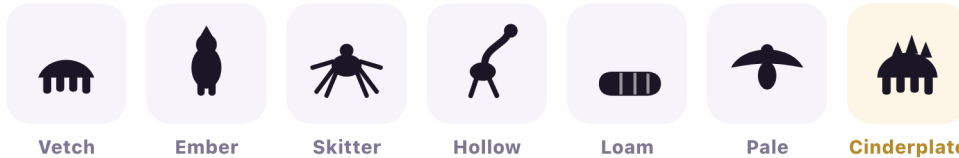
The 40px proof

TRUE SIZE · THE HARNESS

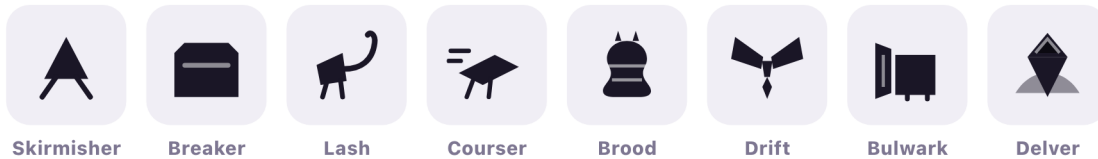
Rendered at the size they appear on a lane row — not zoomed. Squint, or lean back: the ones you cannot name are the ones that need work. Use the tweak panel to retest at 24px or 64px.

40px BLACK FILL

SIX FOUNDERS + HERO



EIGHT RAIDERS



What the proof found

FIVE COLLISIONS · EACH WITH A FIX



Fifteen shapes on eight counter axes is a lot of silhouette to keep distinct. These five pairs currently read as the same mass at 40px — and two of them are actively dangerous, because the pair sits on *different* counter axes. Mistaking one for the other makes a player bring the wrong trait and lose a wave for reasons they cannot see.

COLLISION 01 · DANGEROUS

3 SHAPES

The wedge pile-up



Skirmisher



Courser



Delver

Three angular wedges answered by three different traits — Splash, Chill and Burrow. Worst offender in the cast.

FIX · POINT DIRECTION

Give each wedge one axis and never reuse it. Skirmisher points **up**, Courser points **forward** and sits low, Delver points **down** out of a spoil mound. Direction of the point becomes the name.

COLLISION 02 · DANGEROUS

CROSS-SIDE

Pale reads as Drift



Pale · founder



Drift · raider

A winged thing on your side and a winged thing attacking you. This one breaks the friend-or-foe read, which is the worst thing a silhouette can do.

FIX · CONVEX VS NOTCHED

Pale is **one unbroken arc** — a single convex curve, body tucked under the centre. Drift is **two separate hard wings with a gap at the spine** and a stinger hanging below. Continuous curve equals ally; split and spiked equals enemy.

COLLISION 03

Loam reads as Brood



Loam · founder



Brood · raider

Both are legless segmented masses. Cross-side again, though less punishing — Brood announces itself by splitting.

FIX · HORIZONTAL VS VERTICAL

Loam lies **flat along the ground** with even segments and blunt ends. Brood stacks **upright** with uneven bulges, pinched seams and a spiked crown — it should look ready to burst, because it is.

COLLISION 04

Hollow reads as Skitter



Hollow



Skitter

Two spindly small-bodied founders. Both yours, so no friend-or-foe risk — but Hollow carries Pierce, the trait the endgame gates on, and players must find it instantly in a roster.

FIX · ASYMMETRY VS STARBURST

Hollow is **asymmetric** — two stilts and a long neck reaching off to one side, an L-shape. Skitter is **radially symmetric** — six legs evenly around a centre, no neck. One leans, one spreads.

COLLISION 05

Vetch reads as Breaker



Vetch · founder



Breaker · raider

Both are wide low blocks — the two walls of the game facing each other. Nearly resolved already, worth protecting deliberately.

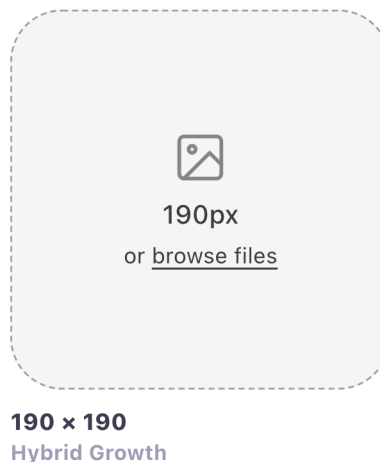
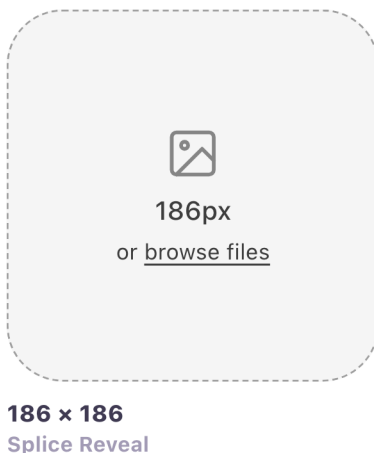
FIX · DOME VS FLAT, LEGS VS NONE

Vetch keeps a curved dome and four visible legs below the shell. Breaker is flat-topped with no legs showing — it slides rather than walks. Curve plus legs equals yours.

Hero art slots

CINDERPLATE · THE ONLY ART THE BUILD IS WAITING ON

Three live slots in the build, all showing the same creature. Drop art straight onto these boxes to see it at true size before committing — they are the real dimensions from the screens, not previews.



WORTH FIXING IN CODE

186 and 190 are the same asset with four pixels of pointless variance. Ship one 192px master and let both screens use it — I can align the two screens to 192 on request.

HEX SAFE AREA

The 96px slot is clipped to a hexagon, so corners are lost. Keep the whole silhouette inside a centred circle at 86% of the width — crest tips included, or they get shaved.

DELIVERY

Transparent PNG at 3× (576px master), plus a flat 40px black silhouette per creature for the lane rows. The silhouette is a separate asset, not a downscale.

Growth ramp

RULE 03 MADE LITERAL

Four stages of one animal. The outline never changes — mass moves outward and downward, the crest grows last. A player must recognise their own creature at every stage, so nothing is added that was not there at runt.



STAGE 01
Runt

Crest is three nubs.
Legs longer than
the body is tall.



STAGE 02
Yearling

Shell widens past
the legs. Crest
reaches full height.



STAGE 03
Warform

Legs thicken to
stumps. Shell
overhangs at the
front.



STAGE 04 · APEX
Apex

Overflows the
frame. Shell
darkens; crest
glows.

THE TRAP TO AVOID

Do not make apex a new creature with horns and armour plates. The reward for growing is *your* animal getting imposing, not a stranger arriving. If the artist wants to add a part, it goes on all four stages as a nub first.

Palette per line

BODY · HIGHLIGHT · SHADOW



Vetch line

#6ba7c0 · #8dc0d4 · #4f8ba3
Carapace, Taunt



Ember line

#e5867a · #f2ada3 · #c2695c
Cinder, Splash



Skitter line

#e8b34a · #f2ca77 · #c49a3a
Sprint, Litter



Hollow line

#7a6ac0 · #a294d8 · #6b5fa8
Reach, Pierce



Loam line

#7cc492 · #9ed3ad · #5aa87a

Regrow, Burrow



Pale line

#a9b0c4 · #c1c7d6 · #8d94ab

Screen, Chill



All raiders

#4b455f · #6a6383 · #3a3550

Coral #d4776a marks the hurting part only

✓ Do

Draw the 40px silhouette **first**, then render up. Anything that fails as a black mass will not be rescued by detail.

Keep one signature protruding part per creature — the crest, the neck, the whip. That part is the whole read at small size.

Point the creature slightly toward the viewer's right. Every screen assumes threats come from the right.

Give founders visible eyes. Give raiders none — the coral accent is where they hurt you, not where they look.

✗ Don't

No gradients or texture inside the body. Flat fill plus one ink contour, or it turns to mud on a lane.

Never average two parents into a smooth blend — a hybrid keeps one body and **bolts on the other's part**.

No cute faces on raiders, and no gore on founders. The tonal line is "strange but soft" on your side, "hard and blank" on theirs.

Don't reuse a point direction, a leg count, or a wing shape that another creature already owns. Check the harness above before drawing.



Next: the five fixes above are described, not drawn. Say the word and I'll redraw the affected silhouettes in the Character Bible so the Bible and this spec agree — Skirmisher, Courser, Delver, Pale, Drift, Loam, Brood and Hollow are the eight that move.